

RAHUL SINGH/ANI

STILL IN THE CANS



RRR
S.S. Rajamouli's magnum opus is the most adversely affected release

PRITHVIRAJ
Yash Raj-produced historical was supposed to be the first of Akshay's five 2022 releases





JERSEY
The Hindi remake of a popular Telugu film is now looking for a new release date



VALIMAI
The wait gets longer for what is Tamil superstar Ajith's first film in over two years



RADHE SHYAM
Pan India release of this romantic drama with Prabhas is on hold

bling for the next lucrative window. "It is not just a delayed release, it also means considerable amount of interest accumulating on the money invested," says Nitin Tej Ahuja, CEO of the Producers Guild of India.

Even a small disruption will prove costly for an industry which saw its overall domestic box office revenues of Rs 11,500 crore in 2019 drop to Rs 2,500 crore in 2020—a 78 per cent fall as per the EY and FICCI Media & Entertainment Report published in March 2021. The scenario wasn't any better in 2021. For instance, the Hindi film box office collected a measly Rs 500 crore as compared to the Rs 3,900 crore in 2019, indicating an 87 per cent drop in earnings. Even as revenues fell, film production costs shot up as producers had to set aside money for mass testing of cast and crew, Covid insurance and sanitisation of sets. Many producers were forced to move production out of Mumbai on account of restrictions resulting in additional costs.

The industry is already abuzz with more producers taking the direct-to-OTT release route. Trade expert Manobala Vijayabalan shared on Twitter that a leading streaming platform was offering the makers of *Radhe Shyam* starring *Bahubali* star Prabhas Rs 400 crore to skip a theatrical run. Mankad believes that "a lot of mid-budget films" will opt for streaming, given that the recent money-spinners in cinemas have all been big-screen spectacles. "Audiences are aware that such a film will arrive on OTT platforms within four weeks," he added. Ahuja is empathetic of the compulsions which make producers take to streaming. "One often tries to pitch theatrical versus digital. From a producer's point of view, you'd obviously want your finger in both pies," says Ahuja. "But there is a limit to how long you can hold on to a film. Prolific producers may have future projects planned, assuming that revenue will come in from theatres but that isn't the case since the film is stuck."

Questions will arise if big studios like Yashraj Films, which have thus far resisted offers from OTT, start reconsidering its strategy for big-ticket releases *Prithviraj* (period drama with Akshay) and *Jayeshbhai Jordaar* (social comedy with Ranveer Singh). The road to recovery is uncertain but there's also a sense of familiarity on how to deal with the adversary. "The entire producer, distribution and exhibition community are a lot more informed of the risks," says Gianchandani, who is also CEO of PVR Pictures. He expects the industry to bounce back quicker than they did after the second wave. The conviction stems from recent trends such as the latest Spider-Man recording the second highest advance booking ever. "This whole inference that the box office will take a lot of time to reach the pre-Covid level, [viewership] habits will change or the number of films will reduce, all has come to an end," he says. "Cinemas are truly back." Only the pandemic is an intermission the industry would like to do without. ■